

muscle to fight the BJP's communalism on its own. The BJP wins only because the Opposition is divided. Our unity will ensure its end. It's not happening only due to the ego and superiority complex of the Congress. It must understand the ground political reality, shed its superiority complex and accommodate all Opposition parties with equity. Unfortunately, they are fighting Hindutva with soft Hindutva. They did so in Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan. The Congress is yet to realise its strategic follies. It doesn't come across as sincere in fighting the BJP's communal agenda. In Kerala, too, some Congress leaders openly stated they could join the BJP. This phenomenon continues to haunt the Congress because the leaders share a common ideological basis. We have a different political path.

On the LDF's prospects in 2024

We will win a majority of the seats. In our seven and a half years, we made giant leaps in developing Kerala even as the Union government throttled us with sanctions and restricted our borrowing limit. Every day, we face such restrictions, but have survived the mess with alternatives. We are not ready to yield to undemocratic directives. It's a fight for the dignity of the people of Kerala. ■

JHARKHAND

The Great Heist

By Amitabh Srivastava

Some 25 counting machines whirred breathlessly as they went through bundle after bundle of cash. A few gave up and broke down, but around 10 more were on standby for precisely such contingencies. By the end of that exercise on December 10, the machines, after hours of work, had already counted notes worth hundreds of crores of rupees. The exact figure is yet to come in, but many peg it at much over Rs 300 crore. If the Congress was looking to recover some moral salve from its electoral debris in three big heartland states in the week gone by, having the liquor company run by the family of one of its parliamentarians plastered all over town as the protagonist in a jaw-dropping case of tax evasion was hardly it. Not just an ordinary one either. The seizure associated with its three-time Rajya Sabha MP from Jharkhand, Dhiraj Sahu, is reputedly set to go down in the record books as the highest-ever haul of unaccounted-for cash in a single operation by the income tax department.

The swoop on Boudh Distillery Private Limited (BDPL), the largest of its ilk in Odisha, started on December 6 after a tip-off. Over 40 locations—including Sahu's Ranchi residence and an ancestral home in Lohardaga—have been raided since; many more linked entities are under the scanner. Of the three other companies under the group, one, Baldeo Sahu Infra Pvt Ltd, is led by Sahu's son Harshit. Sahu himself has investments in M/S Baldeo Sahu & Sons, though it's unclear whether these are linked



SOMNATH SEN



HAUL OF SHAME
Seized cash being counted; (right) Dhiraj Sahu